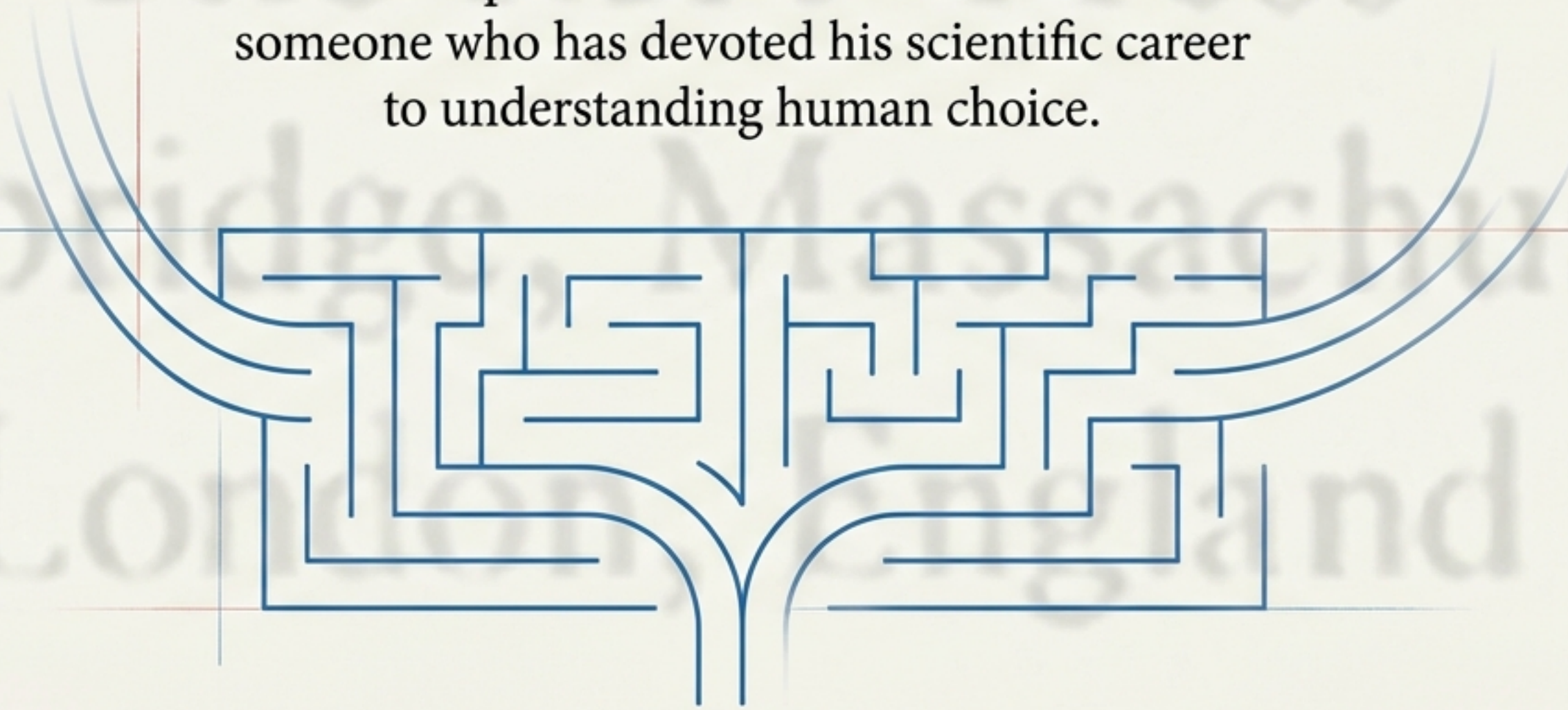


Mazes Without Minotaurs

The Intellectual Journey of Herbert A. Simon

The metaphor of the maze is irresistible to someone who has devoted his scientific career to understanding human choice.



Life is not a unified theme or a straight line. It is a series of branching paths taken without knowledge of the future. Simon describes his life as a maze, but a benign one—"without Minotaurs"—where choices are determined not by heroic foresight, but by the immediate environment and the limits of human rationality.

THE BOY IN WISCONSIN: ORIGIN OF THE OBSERVER

Epistemological Relativism born from physical difference

THE STRAWBERRY PATCH



At age four, Simon **fails** to find **strawberries**. He learns the real world 'out there' is not identical to the **perceived world**.

THE **OUTSIDER**



Left-handed, Jewish in a German neighborhood, intellectually precocious. An **observer** rather than a participant.

THE **DEMOCRATIC CREDO**



A grounding in **equality** from the family maid: "Your shit don't smell like ice cream neither."

The Simon Method: The Art of Self-Instruction

Subject: LANGUAGES

Method: Read Rousseau and Montesquieu directly.

Insight: The great enemy of foreign language learning is a sense of shame.

Subject: MATHEMATICS

Method: Independent study after being kicked out of calculus.

Insight: Learned logic and higher math by doing, not listening.

Subject: SOCIAL SCIENCE

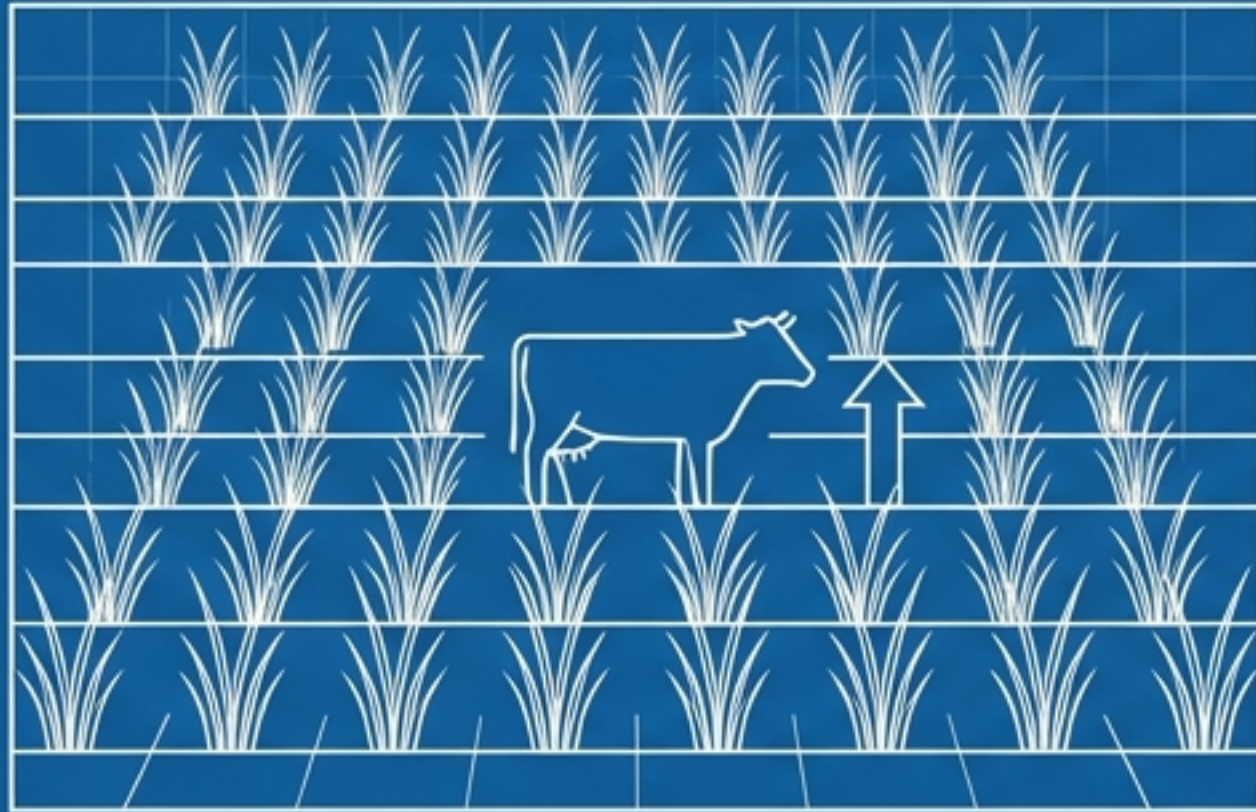
Method: Reading Uncle Harold's copy of *The Federalist Papers*.

Insight: Human behavior can be studied scientifically.

Simon believed that with a library card and an index, he could master any subject. He did not wait to be taught.

THE ROCKMARSH PIVOT: THEORY VS. REALITY

THE THEORY



The Physiocrat's Dream: Buy cheap marshland. Plant Reed Canary Grass. Fatten cattle for market. The logic is flawless.

THE REALITY

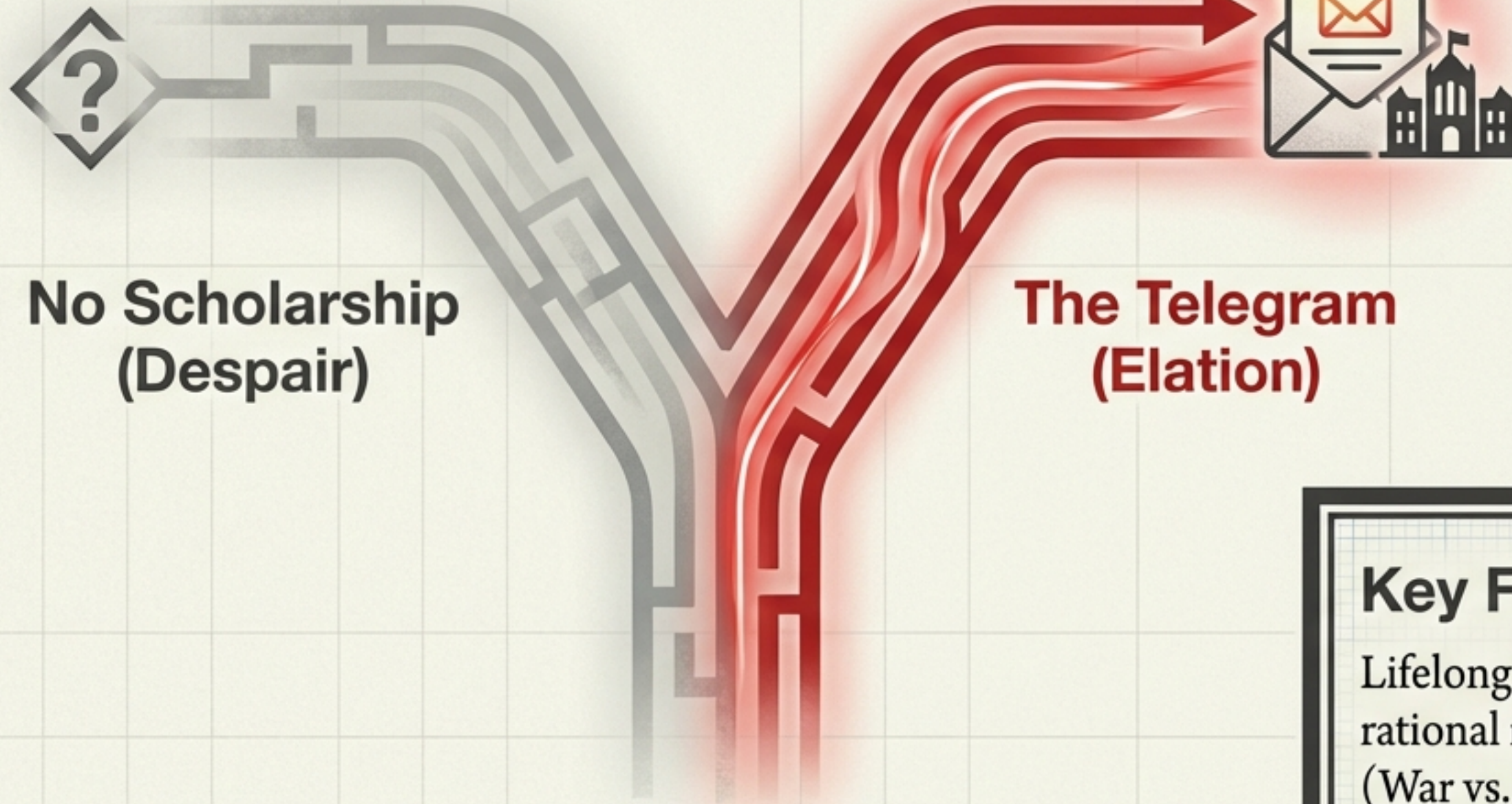


The Obstinate Facts: Cows refused the grass. They broke fences to escape. Theories were destroyed by the facts of the real world.

Legacy: A lifelong skepticism of abstract, a priori economic theories that ignore actual behavior.

The Maze: A Branching Point

The Chicago Crucible

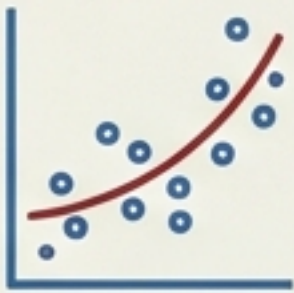


1930s UChicago:
An "Intellectual Monastery."
Debates: Stalinist vs. Trotskyite.
Curriculum: The Great Books.
Outcome: Entering as a socialist,
leaving as a logical positivist.

Key Figure: Harold Guetzkow

Lifelong friend and sparring partner. Proved that rational men can reach opposite conclusions (War vs. Pacifism) from the same world.

The Mentors: Ingredients of a Revolution



Henry Schultz

The Econometrician

Taught the rigor of connecting math to data. Rejected elegant formulas if they didn't fit the statistical facts.

$P \Rightarrow Q$

	T	T	Q
P	1	0	0
F	1	1	1

Rudolf Carnap

The Logician

Leader of Logical Positivism. Taught the strict syntax of science. Accepted Simon's correction to "The Logical Syntax of Language".



Nicholas Rashevsky

The Mathematical Biophysicist

Modeled biological systems. Taught that complex behaviors could be modeled mathematically.

The Merriam Enterprise

Making Politics a Science



Merriam's Machine

Charles Merriam turned the UChicago Political Science department into a research machine. He sought to “fuse intelligence with faith” to master social forces.

The Behavioral Shift

The Shift: From Moral Philosophy to Behavioralism.
The Method: Dissolving boundaries. Mixing psychology, sociology, and statistics.

Simon's Role

Simon's Role: A “private in Merriam's army.” Absorbing the ethos that political science could use the tools of hard science—measurement, quantification, and observation.

The Scientist as a Young Man: Measuring the City

The First Encounter with Computation

Using a sorting machine at the university bookstore to process municipal data for the ICMA.

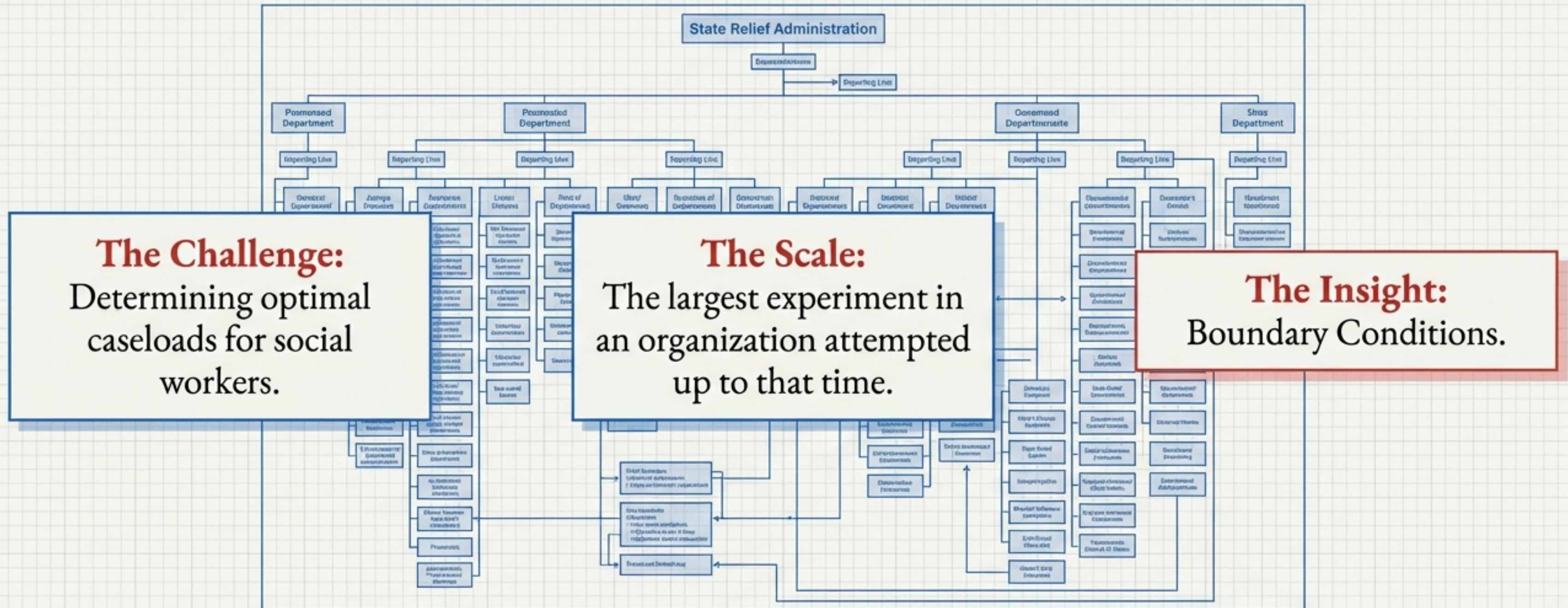
Insight: Realizing a machine could be “wired” to manipulate symbols, not just numbers.

1. Measuring Municipal Activities (Fire depts, libraries).
2. Learning that organizations are systems of decision-making.
3. Lesson: A little administrative experience goes a long way.

The Maze: West to Berkeley (1939)

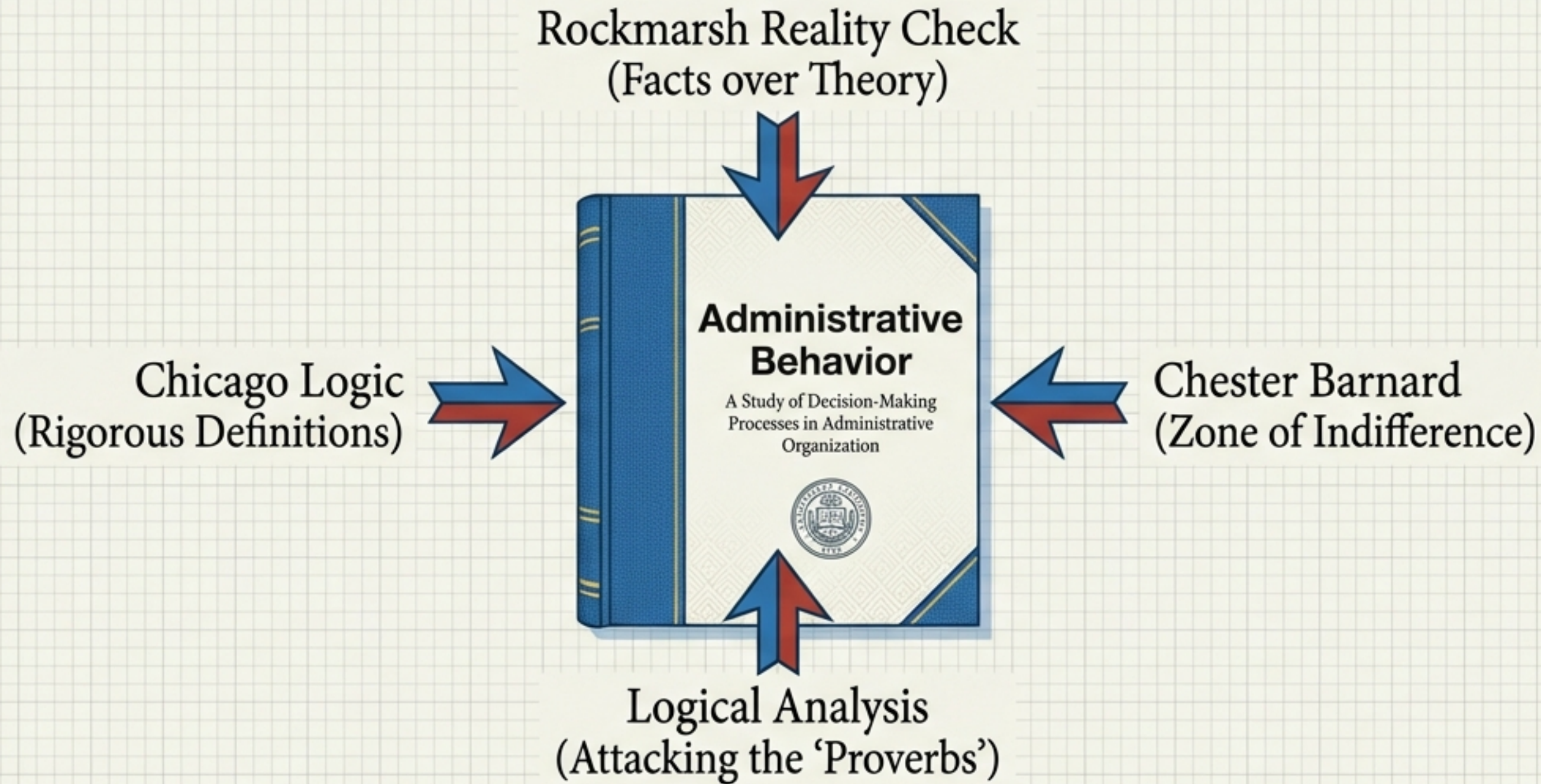


The Laboratory of the Real: The SRA Experiment



In a parallel study on taxes, Simon discovered that rationality depends on what factors an actor takes into account vs. what they ignore. This was the precursor to Bounded Rationality.

The Synthesis: Administrative Behavior



The Thesis: Decision-making is the heart of administration. It is not about perfect utility maximization; it is about how organizations influence the limits of an individual's decision-making.

The Core Theory: Bounded Rationality

SATISFICING

Humans do not maximize.
We look for a course of action
that is 'good enough'.

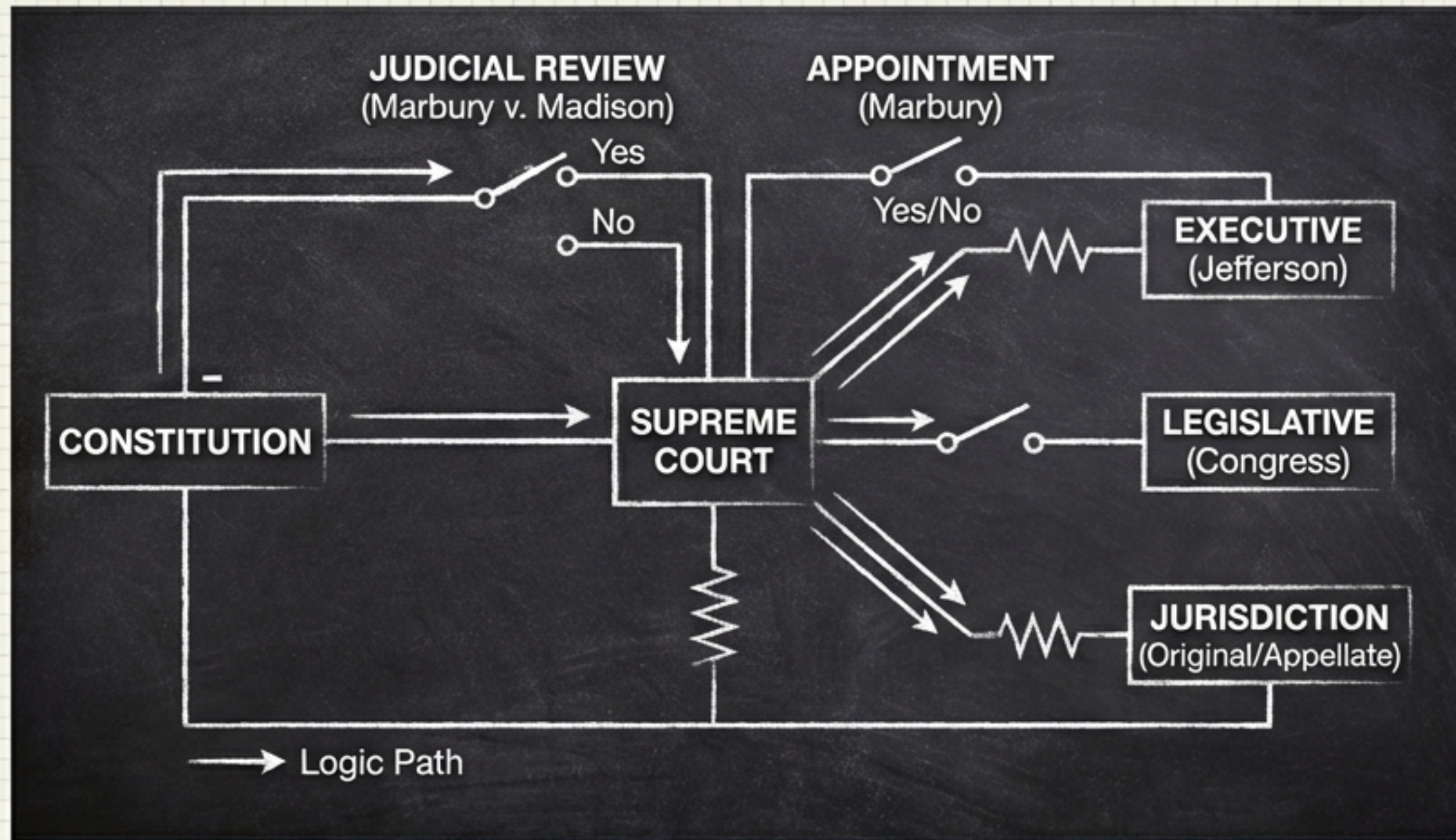
Rationality is bounded by:

- Incomplete information
- Cognitive limitations
- Time constraints

“Administrative theory must be concerned with the limits of rationality.”

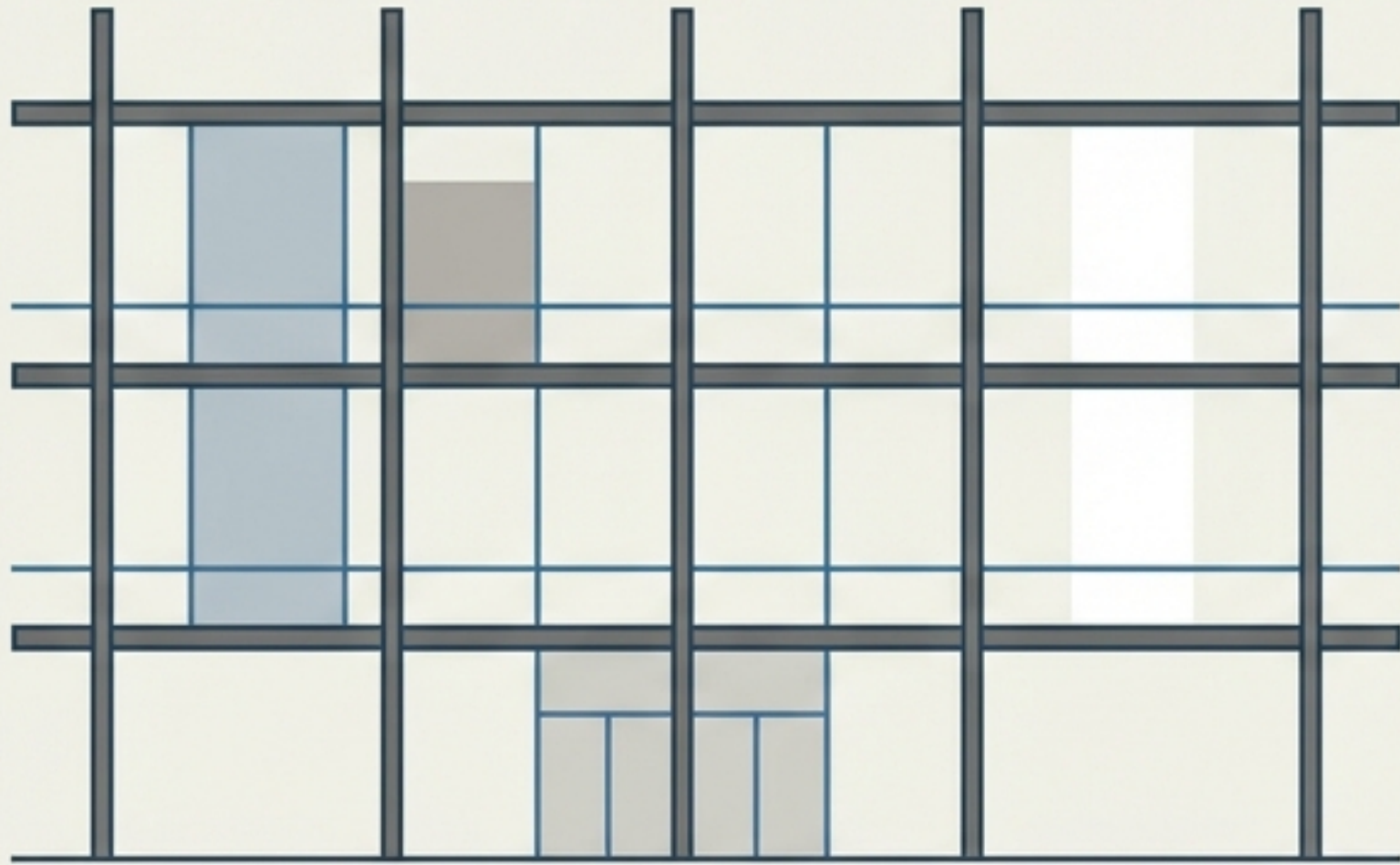
The Teacher at Illinois Tech

Wiring the Supreme Court



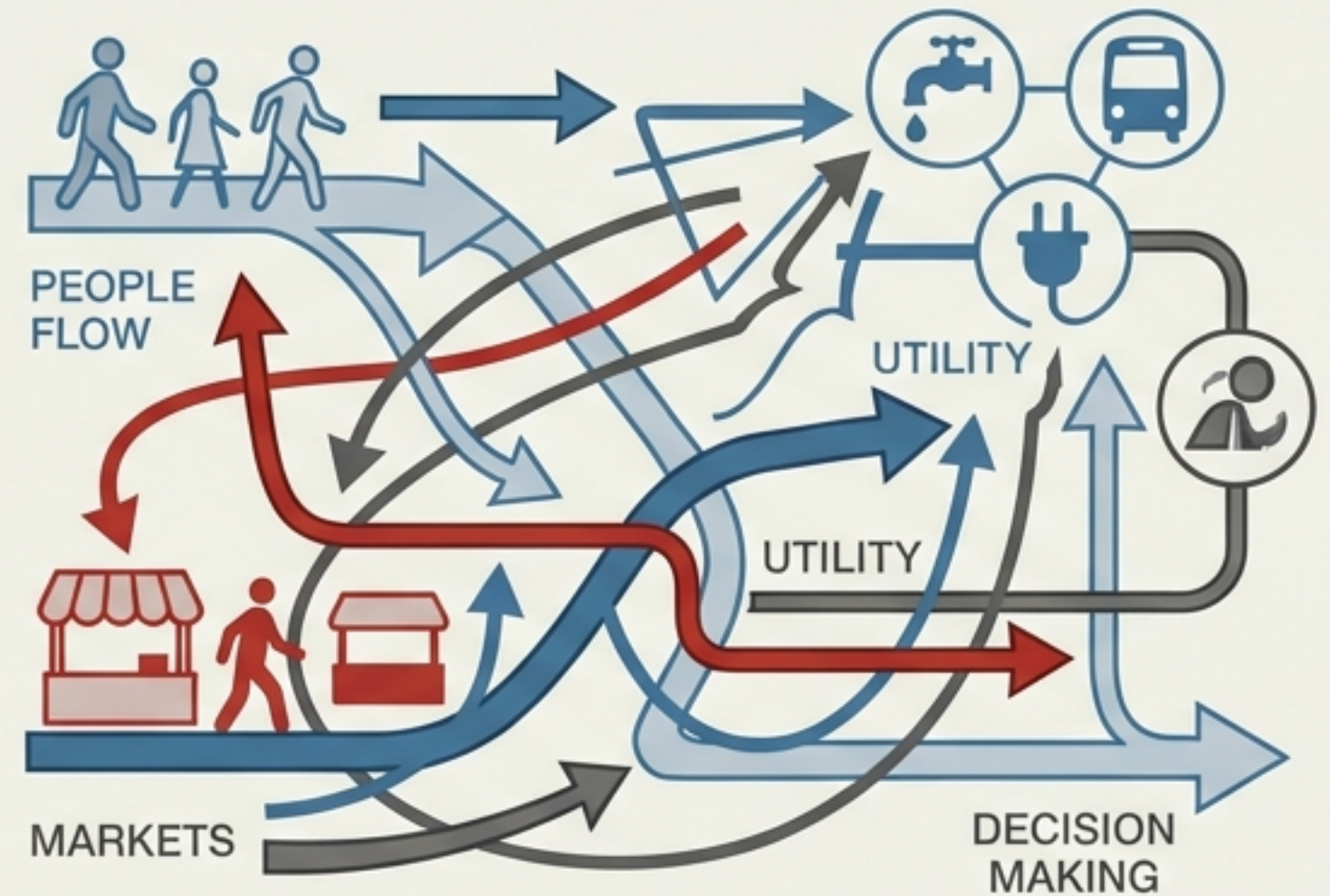
- **The Audience:** Pragmatic engineering students.
- **The Method:** Using wiring diagrams to explain Constitutional Law.
- **The Philosophy:** “Enlightenments, like accidents, happen only to prepared minds.”

The Clash of Models: The Missionary among Architects



Mies's Functionalism: Structural Honesty (Art).

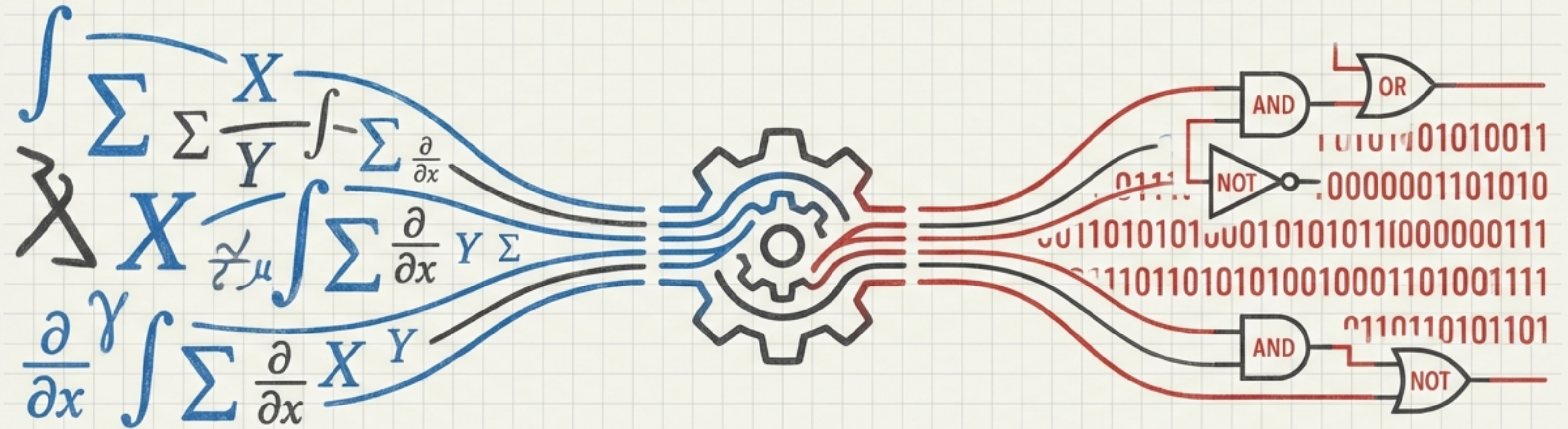
Mies's Verdict on the Client: Smoke cigars and drink Riesling until they "begin to like" the design.



Simon's Functionalism: Utility (Decision Making).

Simon's Verdict: No society is affluent enough to provide architects with all the steel and glass to save their artistic souls.

The Pre-Dawn of AI: Mathematical Foundations



- 📖 **The Pursuit:** Self-education in higher mathematics and logic.
- 📖 **The Output:** Formalization of the axioms of Newtonian mechanics.
- 📖 **The Leap:** Realizing that computers could manipulate SYMBOLS, not just numbers.

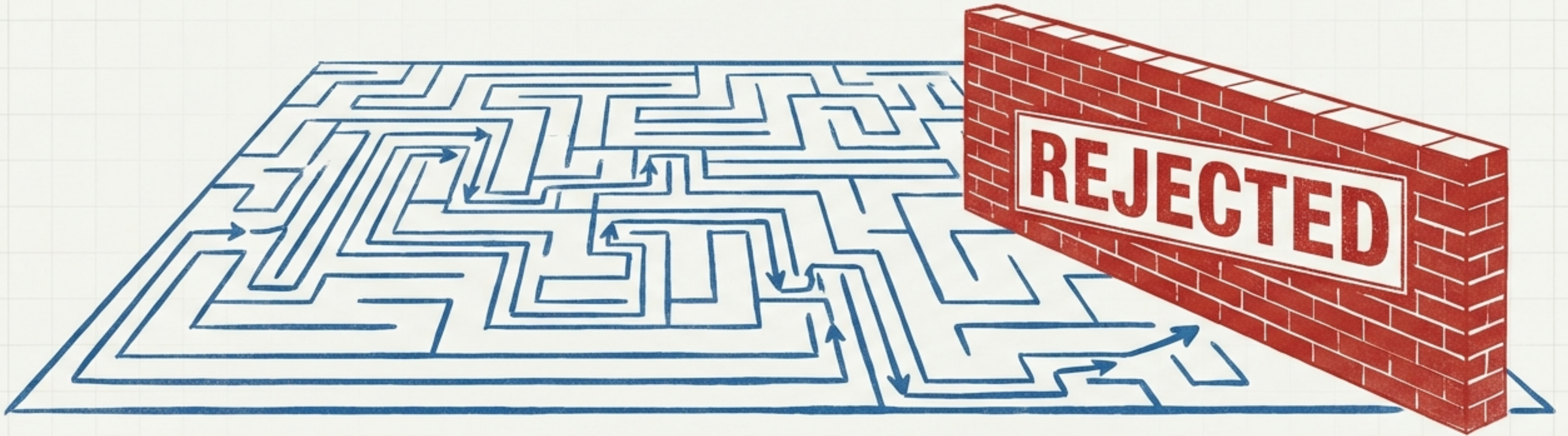
Personal Threads: Dorothea

The Meeting: June 15, 1937. Simon's 21st Birthday.

The Logic: Simon deduced she had red hair ("I had early been told that there were no green-haired people...").

The Partnership: A shared intellectual and political life. Dorothea provided the optimism and social grace that counterbalanced Simon's introversion.

The War Years: A Maze Closed Off



- **The Intent:** Simon sought a commission to fight in WWII.
- **The Obstacle:** Color Blindness.
- **The Bureaucracy:** A waiver secured, then rejected because “the damned Democrats changed the rules again.”
- **The Lesson:** The “Maze” of life often closes doors. One must navigate the path that remains open.

The Identity: Scientist as Problem Solver

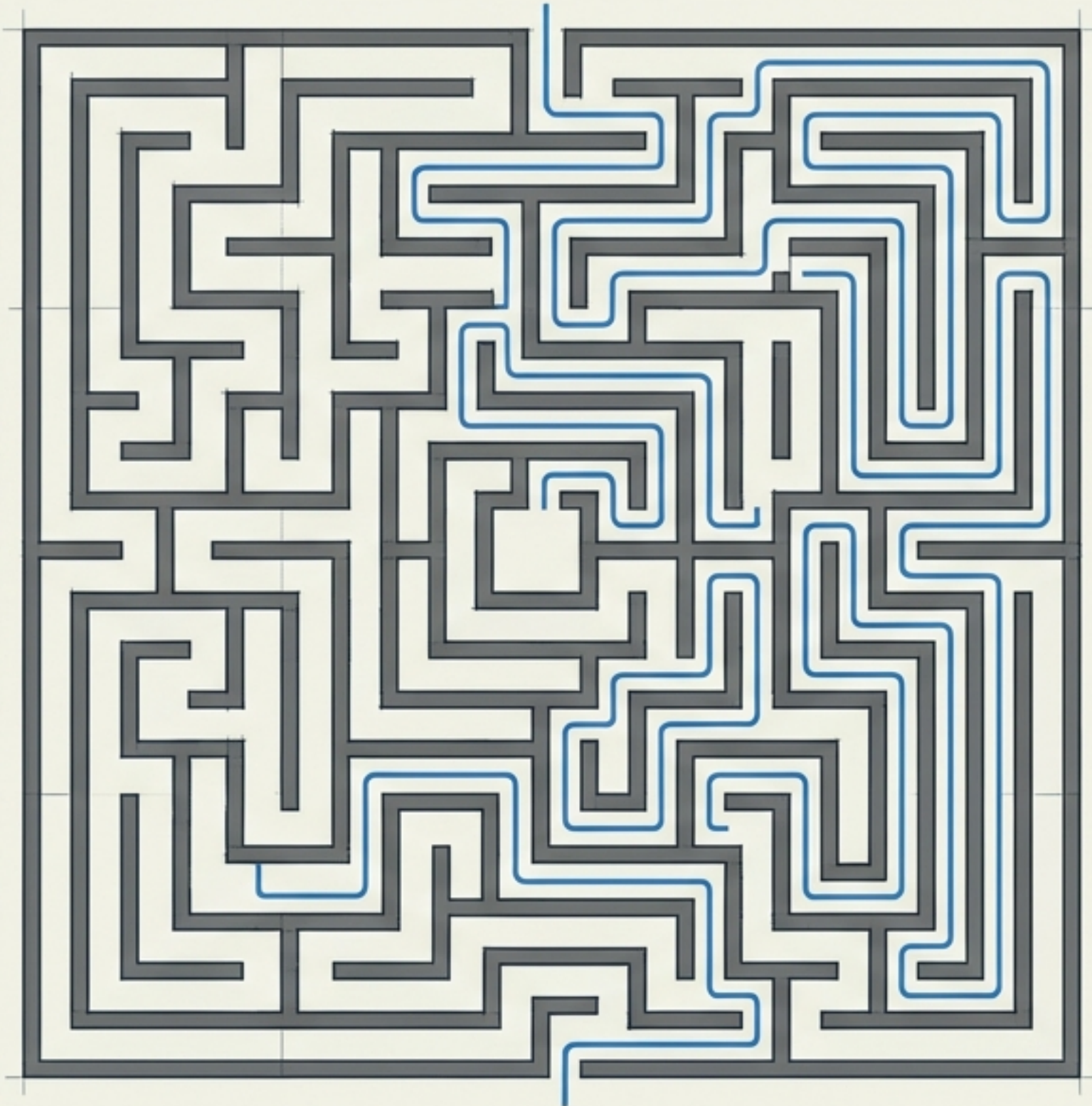


Self-Definition: “I have been a scientist, but in many sciences.”

The Unifying Thread: The search for truth about how humans think and decide.

The Work: An “elaborate gloss” on the core ideas of Administrative Behavior.

Conclusion: The View from the Path



- **The Metaphor:** Life is a maze without a singular 'Minotaur' or 'Golden Thread'.
- **The Takeaway:** We cannot optimize our entire lives. We satisfice—making the best choice available at each branching point.
- **Result:** A complex, continuous, and navigated path.